

There is no genuine copula in Japanese — a reanalysis of 'da' as Postposition plus Existential Verb¹

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Abstract

This paper proposes a new analysis of the Japanese so-called copula *dearu* and its contracted form *da*. Traditionally, *dearu* has been regarded as a single copular verb equivalent to English *to be*. However, the separability between *de* and *aru* and the inseparability between NPs and *de* show that this interpretation is inadequate. In sentences such as *kare=wa gakusei dearu* 'he is a student', the noun phrase *gakusei* plus *de* behaves as a single constituent, while *de* and *aru* are separable. This suggests that *gakusei de* forms a postpositional phrase (PP) and that *dearu* should be reanalysed as the postposition *de* plus the existential verb *aru*.

Under this analysis, *kare=wa gakusei dearu* is syntactically an existential sentence consisting of the core clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. The non-deletability of the syntactic adjunct *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability rather than from syntactic necessity, since *gakusei=de* functions as the focus of the sentence. The paper also accounts for the default negation pattern *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* (partial negation) instead of *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* (total negation), showing that the negator applies to the adjunct domain *gakusei=de* rather than to the existence of *kare* itself.

This reanalysis thus provides a unified account of the structure, semantics and historical development of Japanese *da/dearu* constructions.

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1. Introduction — Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu* and inseparability between NPs and *de*

In Japanese linguistics, *da* and *dearu*, as in *kare=wa gakusei=**da*** / *gakusei **dearu*** 'he is a student' ("=" indicates enclisis), have traditionally been treated as copulas equivalent to *to be* in English. However, this analysis faces a major limitation: it cannot account for the **high degree of independence between *de* and *aru* in *dearu***.

For example, when the noun *gakusei* 'student' is marked by the focus particle — the so-called *toritatesi* in Japanese — *mo* 'also', the sentence cannot take the form **kare=wa gakusei=mo dearu* 'he is also a student' but must be *kare=wa gakusei de=mo aru* 'idem.', where *mo* is inserted between *de* and *aru*. Furthermore, in *kare=wa gakusei deari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin da* 'he is a student, and she is a professional', the first *deari* may reduce to *de* alone as in *kare=wa gakusei **de**, kanozyo=wa syakaizin da* 'idem.'. These facts show that ***de* and *aru* are separable**, whereas **the NP *gakusei* and *de* always remain contiguous** as *gakusei de*, as follows:

Kare=wa gakusei de aru.

Kare=wa gakusei de mo aru.

Kare=wa gakusei de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin da.

Hence, in *kare=wa gakusei dearu*, the sequence *gakusei* plus *de* constitutes a single inseparable constituent, as Dalla Chiesa (2015) notes: "the NP-*de* element must always be the phrase". This *gakusei de* is formally identical to a **postpositional phrase (PP) consisting of a NP + the postposition =*de***. Therefore, in what follows, *gakusei de* will be treated as a PP, that is, PP *gakusei=de*. This separation between =*de* and *aru* is compatible with Matsuoka's observation that "the copula *da* consists of the postposition *de* and the verb *aru*" (2019: 142).

2. NP + =*de* as an adjunct PP and the one-argument existential verb *aru*

In Japanese, PPs of the form "NP + =*de*" function generally as adjuncts. Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* consists syntactically of a **mandatory structure [*kare=wa aru*]** and an **adjunct structure [*gakusei=de*]**.

In *kare=wa aru*, *aru* functions as a one-argument verb. When the verb ***aru* functions as one-argument predicate**, it means '**to exist**' — though rather literary — and the sentence *kare=wa*

aru can thus be interpreted as 'he exists', **asserting the existence** of *kare*. As for the PP *gakusei=de*, on the other hand, although **PPs headed by =de** can express a variety of semantic roles such as location, means or cause, in this case it can be interpreted as neither means nor cause. The most plausible interpretation is therefore **locative** — not a physical but a **conceptual location**.

Consequently, *gakusei=de* means 'in the conceptual domain "student"'. The entire structure *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is thus, syntactically, composed of **the mandatory clause [*kare wa aru*]** 'he exists' and **the adjunct [*gakusei=de*]** 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or, more simply, 'as a student'. Semantically, it expresses 'He exists, and the location of his existence is the conceptual domain of "student"' or, more simply, 'He exists, and it is as a student'. Schematically, *A=wa B=de aru* can be represented as $E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$, where $E(A)$ — E abbreviates EXIST — denotes the **assertion of existence** and $IN(A, B)$ the **specification of the domain of existence**.

3. The difference between *kare=wa gakusei=DE ARu* and *sore=wa gakkō=NI ARu*

In contrast to the construction *kare=wa gakusei=de aru*, hypothesised as **existential** in Section 2, in genuine **locative** constructions such as *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school' and *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru* 'it is in the school', the **locative argument is obligatory and always marked by the postposition =ni, rather than =de**. This formal difference further supports the above analysis. The verb *aru* — more precisely, its stem *ar-* — when used as a locative verb, is a two-argument predicate with the argument structure [location, theme], the location being denoted by the postpositional phrase [NP + =ni], as in *sore=wa gakkō=ni aru*. When the theme is animate, the verb *iru* with the stem *i-* is used instead, with the argument PP [NP + =ni] unchanged, as in *kare=wa gakkō=ni iru* 'he is in the school', whereas **kare=wa gakkō=de iru*, which employs the PP [NP + =de], is not semantically interpretable — even for native speakers — and ungrammatical.

Accordingly, *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* should be regarded *syntactically* — though *not pragmatically or informationally*, as will be discussed in Section 4 — as a structurally self-contained existence-assertive clause *kare=wa aru* 'he exists', accompanied by the adjunct *gakusei=de*, which specifies the domain of existence.

4. The syntactic optionality and pragmatic necessity of *gakusei=de*

Although *gakusei=de* in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* is **syntactically an adjunct**, it **cannot be deleted**. This is because the sentence, while structurally consisting of the mandatory core *kare=wa aru* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=de* 'in the conceptual domain "student"' or 'as a student', serves as a **presentational sentence** in which **the focus is domaind on *gakusei=de***.

Therefore, the **non-deletability of *gakusei=de* arises from its pragmatic and informational indispensability** rather than from syntactic necessity. The distinction can be represented as follows:

Level	Structure	Function
Syntax	[NP <i>A ar-</i>] + [PP <i>B=de</i>]	One-argument predicate + adjunct
Semantics	"A exists, and it is in the domain B"	Existence + its domain restriction
Information Structure	[<i>A=wa aru</i>] + [<i>B=de</i>]	Given + New (default)
Pragmatics	Focus on <i>B=de</i> (default)	Pragmatic obligatoriness and non-deletability of <i>B=de</i> due to focus

5. Old Japanese forms

In Old Japanese, the mordern *kare=wa gakusei=**de** aru* would correspond to *kare gakusei **nari***, derived from *kare gakusei=**ni** ari*. Before the emergence of the postposition-suffix sequence *=nite*, the postposition *=ni* could mark both arguments and adjuncts. Thus, *kare gakusei=**ni** ari* can be analysed as consisting of the core clause *kare ari* 'he exists' and the adjunct *gakusei=**ni*** 'in the conceptual domain denoted by *gakusei*', which is consistent with the present hypothesis.

The subsequent development *kare gakusei=**nari** → kare gakusei=**nite** ari → kare=wa gakusei=**de** aru* reflects the diachronic split between *=ni*, used for arguments, and *=nite*, used for adjuncts. This may represent a shift from a linguistic stage in which *=ni* marked both arguments and adjuncts to one in which *=ni* and *=nite* became specialised as argumental and adjunctive markers, respectively — a possibility that requires further historical investigation.

6. Scope of negation denoted by the particle =wa

Negation in *kare=wa gakusei=de aru* 'he exists, and it is as a student' defaultly appears as *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* 'he exists, but it is **not** as a student' (partial negation) — underlyingly, **kare=wa gakusei=de=wa aranai*, since in contemporary Standard Japanese the negative form of the verb *aru* is not the theoretically expected **ara-nai*, but obligatorily the suppletive verbal adjective *nai* — rather than *kare=wa gakusei=de nai* 'he does **not** exist as a student' (total negation) — underlyingly, **kare=wa gakusei=de ara-nai*. This is because the sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de=wa nai* does **not negate the existence of *kare* itself**, but rather **negates *gakusei=de* as the domain of existence**, since in Japanese **the particle =wa can mark the scope of negation**, as in *gakusei=de=wa ... nai*.

Schematically, the partial negation *A=wa B=de=wa nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de=wa ara-nai* — can be represented as $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, in line with Section 2, whereas the total negation *A=wa B=de nai* — underlyingly, **A=wa B=de ara-nai* — can be represented as $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$. The latter, $\neg(E(A) \wedge IN(A, B))$, is ambiguous, as it can mean either $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ or $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$. Since the interpretation $\neg E(A) \wedge IN(A, B)$ — 'non-existence within a specified domain of existence' — is semantically implausible, the former pattern, which unambiguously denotes $E(A) \wedge \neg IN(A, B)$, is judged to be the more natural one.

Finally, if *dearu* were a single copular unit, partial negation with =wa would necessarily take the form **kare=wa gakusei=wa denai*. The fact that this is ungrammatical further supports the separability of *de* and *aru* and the adjunctive nature of *gakusei=de*.

7. The contracted form =da

In spoken language, the contracted form =da is often used instead of =de *aru*, which is more formal and literal, as in *kare=wa gakusei=da* 'he is a student'. It should be noted that this **contracted form =da** does not represent a new copular category but a **purely phonological reduction of the postpositional-verbal complex =de *aru***. The historical change from =de *aru* to =da, possibly via =dea, involves no syntactic or semantic reanalysis, but only a process of phonetic contraction comparable to French *à le* → *au* 'to the' or Portuguese *de a* → *da* 'from the, of the'. Just as there is no semantic necessity for *à* and *le* to fuse into *au*, or for *de* and *a* into *da* — a phenomenon comparable to the English *to the* or *from the* forming a single word — there is likewise no semantic motivation for =de and *aru* to form a single lexical item.

The two elements remain distinct in their underlying structure: *=de* functions as a postposition indicating the domain in which existence holds, and the stem of *aru* as the existential verb itself. This is precisely why the following colloquial dialogue is possible:

Kare=tte gakusei=da yone? — Iya, gakusei=tte yū=ka, gakusei=de=mo aru=tte kanzi kana.

'He's a student, right?' — 'Well, if you can call him a student, I'd say he's *also* a student, kind of.'

In this dialogue, the interlocutor, recognising that the underlying structure of *gakusei=da* is *gakusei=de aru*, when asked to confirm that *kare*'s domain of existence can be identified as that of 'student', replies that his existence extends to other domains as well, expressed by the form *gakusei=de=mo aru*.

Returning to Section 1, *kare=wa gakusei=de, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=da* 'he (is) a student, and she is a professional' is thus, underlyingly, a compound sentence *kare=wa gakusei=de ari, kanozyo=wa syakaizin=de aru*, in which the first predicate *ari* is deleted as recoverable, on the basis of the structural parallelism between the two coordinate clauses.

Therefore, *=da* as a whole should not be regarded as a copula in the strict sense, but as a **phonologically reduced surface realisation of the underlying construction *=de aru*** (more theoretically, *=de ar-0*, where *ar-* and *-0* represent the stem of the existential verb *aru* and a phonologically zero tense suffix specified as [–past]).

8. Conclusion — *dearu* not as a copula but as the postposition *=de* followed by the existential verb *aru* and *da* as its contracted form

To summarise, the syntactic structure of *A=wa B dearu* 'A is B' consists of a **mandatory existential clause** [*A=wa aru*] 'A exists' and an **adjunctive phrase** [*B=de*] 'in the conceptual domain denoted by B' or 'as B'. It should therefore be syntactically represented as *A=wa B=de aru*. Consequently, treating *dearu* or its contracted form *da* as a single copula is structurally problematic. The form *dearu* is more appropriately analysed as an **existence-domain complex**, composed of the existential verb *aru* and the postpositional phrase *B=de*, which specifies the domain in which the existence of *A* is realised. The more colloquial form *=da* is a phonologically contracted form corresponding to the more formal and literal *=de aru*.

Thus, through the above syntactic analysis, it has been possible to account, by means of a single, consistent principle — namely, the **assertion of existence by** [NP₁ + *aru*] and the **specification of the domain of existence by** [NP₂ + *=de*], schematically represented by $E(NP_1) \wedge IN(NP_1, NP_2)$ — for:

- Separability between *de* and *aru* in *dearu*
- Inseparability between NPs and *de*
- Optional omission of *aru* in *dearu*
- Historical development $A\ B=\mathbf{ni}\ ari \rightarrow A\ B=\mathbf{nari} \rightarrow A\ B=\mathbf{nite}\ ari \rightarrow A=\mathbf{wa}\ B=\mathbf{de}\ ari$
- Ground on which the **default negation** of $A=\mathbf{wa}\ B=\mathbf{de}\ ari$ is not the total $A=\mathbf{wa}\ B=\mathbf{de}\ \mathbf{nai}$ but the **partial** $A=\mathbf{wa}\ B=\mathbf{de}=\mathbf{wa}\ \mathbf{nai}$
- Underlying structure of *=da* as *=de aru*

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